

Think first, then prompt

Critical thinking is what makes AI useful — and safe — in our work. Three questions before every AI task:



01

What am I actually asking?

Name the task before you type. Compare two lists. Find the exceptions. Summarize a policy. Draft a first version. A sharper ask gets a sharper answer.



02

What sources does it need?

Don't assume the AI "just knows." Point it at the right material first — our documentation, the spec, the policy. No sources, no trust.



03

What will I fact-check?

Decide before you read the answer, not after. Names, numbers, versions, claims about functionality — verify anything you'll act on.

RECIPES THAT WORK

Match the tool to the task — then feed it sources



Questions about documentation, features & functionality

→ **Use our internal AI** — it searches our document sources.

THE GROUNDING RECIPE

- 1 Point it at the right document sources for your topic.
- 2 First: “Write a short report on what our docs say about X.”
- 3 Then ask your real question against that report.
- 4 Ask for quotes + doc names so you can spot-check fast.



Creating documents & deliverables

→ **Use Copilot for Word, Excel & Outlook**

It works inside the file. Hand it the source material; review every name and number it writes.



Drafting, brainstorming, rewriting

→ **Any assistant works — the recipe is your judgment.**

The three questions always run first: task, sources, fact-check.

PROMPTS THAT MAKE IT THINK

“Compare these lists — what changed?”

“List the exceptions and edge cases.”

“What would make this answer wrong?”

WHY IT MATTERS · DOCUMENTED CASES, NOT VIBES

Trust, but verify

319

knowledge workers studied

Microsoft Research + Carnegie Mellon, 2025

The more people trusted the AI, the less critical thinking they reported. Confidence in their own expertise went the other way — more checking, sharper results.



The chatbot's answer is your answer

Air Canada, 2024 — a tribunal held the airline liable after its website chatbot invented a bereavement-refund policy that didn't exist. "The AI said it" was no defense.



In healthcare, the stakes are higher

AP investigation, 2024 — an AI transcription tool used by 30,000+ clinicians invented text no one said. Acting on wrong automated output ("automation bias") is a documented risk in clinical software.

AI drafts. You decide. Verify anything that leaves the building — names, numbers, dates, functionality claims.